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Graduate Recruitment Team

Optiver

Strawinskylaan 3095

1077 ZX Amsterdam

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am applying for the Graduate Equity Analyst (2027 Start) role in Amsterdam. I am a final-year Economics student at the University of Strathclyde, graduating in summer 2027 with a predicted 2:1, and my strongest work sits where econometrics meets code. Optiver's Equity Analysts use current events and fundamental research to shape options trading decisions, which is the question my dissertation asks of the gas market: how much does news move volatility?

My dissertation, supervised by Dr Luigi Gifuni, asks whether the news pays when forecasting European gas volatility. I am building a mixed-frequency (MIDAS) model in MATLAB that combines daily storage, market and news-based data, including a gas-market attention index I am constructing from Google Trends. I will evaluate it out-of-sample against HAR and AR benchmarks using Diebold-Mariano tests, then compare the Sharpe ratios of a volatility-targeted TTF futures strategy built on each model. Earlier, I built a Monte Carlo option pricer in which a geometric-Asian control variate cut the standard error of arithmetic-Asian estimates by 97.24% at 100,000 paths, and tested corn and soybean prices for cointegration in R. I work mainly in R and MATLAB and am strengthening my Python.

Quantitative research appeals to me because it is honest: an idea only counts if it survives data it has not seen. Poker taught me the same respect for variance; my lifetime cash-game winnings of over £40,000 came from disciplined bet sizing and a strict 50-buy-in bankroll rule rather than any single good night. I brought that discipline to the Strathclyde Agricapital Society, which I co-founded and grew to 126 members, where I built a wheat calendar-spread strategy whose weekly backtest returned a Sharpe ratio of 0.76 before costs and 0.28 after.

Optiver's Equity Options Trading team stands out to me because its analysts sit on the trading floor and see their research tested against live volatility, starting with training through the Optiver Academy for Equity Analysts. Building a news-attention index has taught me how hard it is to separate information that moves volatility from noise, and I would like to apply that discipline to company events and the options priced on them.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my application. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Yours faithfully,

Will McGowan